Sustainable OSS: lessons from XWiki

Michael Hamann

XWIKI
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About me

- Michael Hamann, living in and working from **Karlsruhe**, Germany
- First open-source contributions in 2006
- Started contributing to **DokuWiki** in 2008
- Studied informatics and did PhD at Karlsruhe Institute of Technology
- Got to know the **XWiki** team at a shared stand at FOSDEM 2016
- Joined product team of **XWiki SAS** in 2021

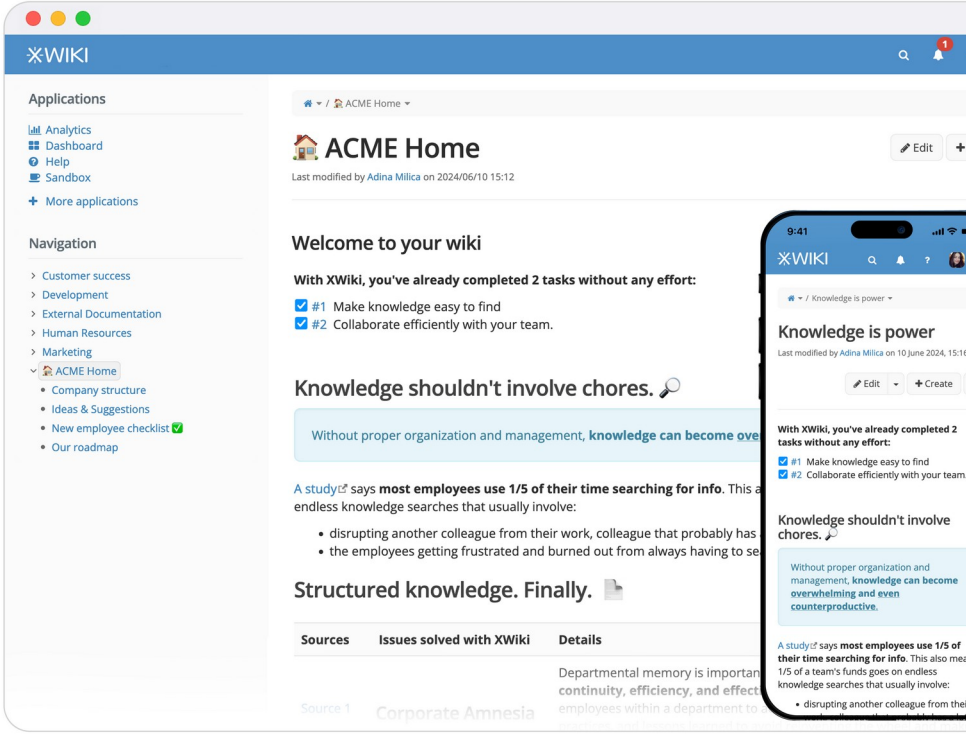
Agenda

- XWiki as software and development platform
- Funding XWiki, XWiki SAS and the community
- DokuWiki vs. XWiki

XWiki

About XWiki

- Since 2003: Collaboration, knowledge management
- A structured open-source enterprise wiki
- A platform for developing web applications
- 100% Open Source, LGPL
- Competitors: Confluence, Notion, Teams Wiki



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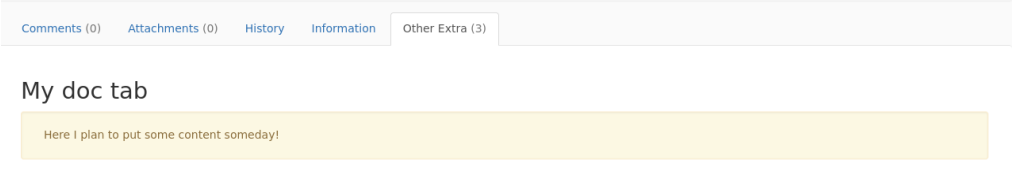
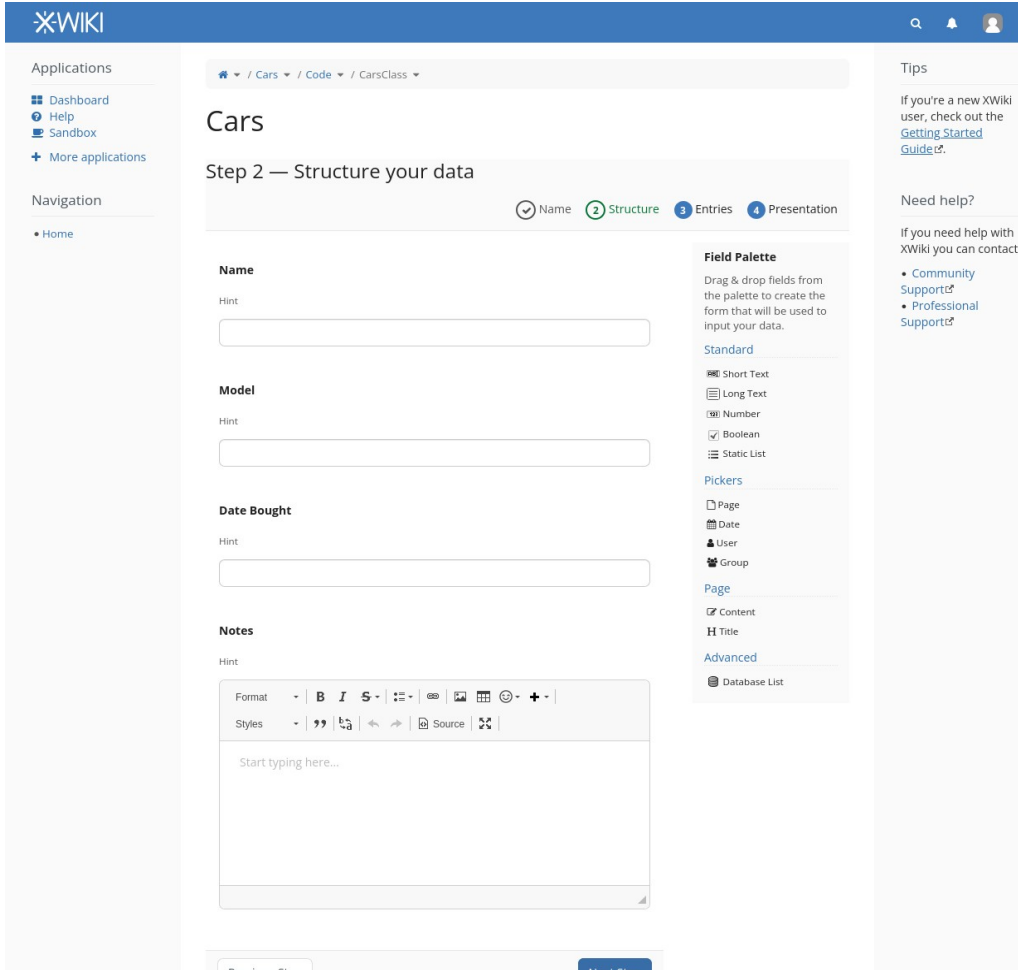
XWiki as a platform



- Modular UI – can be extended
- Every wiki page can contain structured data in addition to content
- Sheets can display structured data in view and edit mode
- Wiki pages can define macros, UI extensions, and more – **customization is a key feature**

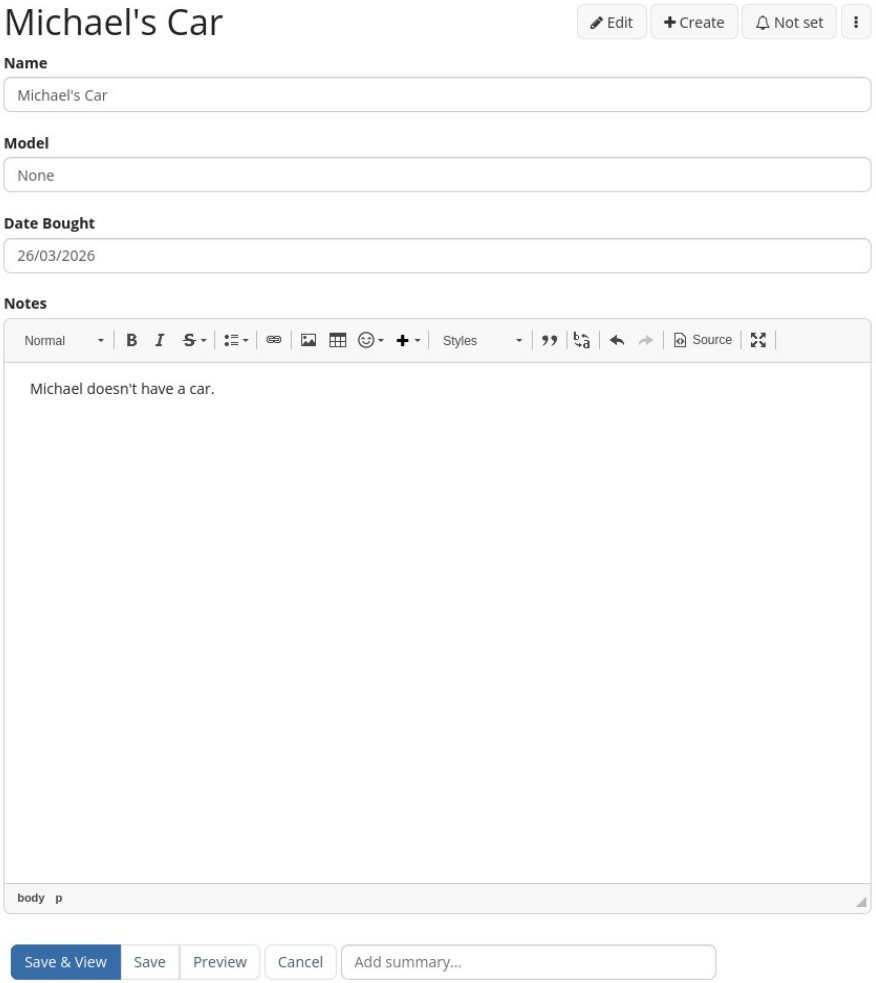
App Within Minutes

- Create your own “applications” with structured data
- Define fields with drag & drop



App Within Minutes

- Structured data entry based on the form



Michael's Car

Last modified by Administrator on 2026/03/20 16:14

Name

Michael's Car

Model

None

Date Bought

26/03/2026

Notes

Michael doesn't have a car.

0 Likes Tags: [+]

Created by Administrator on 2026/03/20 16:14

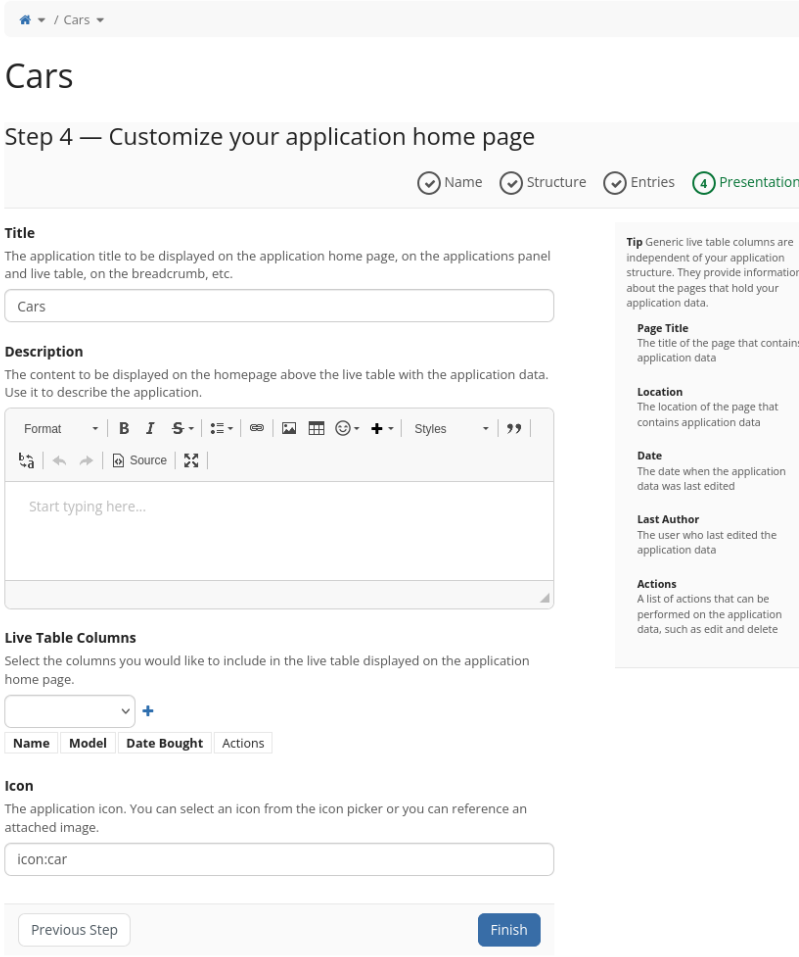
Comments (0) Attachments (0) History Information

No comments for this page

Comment

App Within Minutes

- Define the main application page
- Define which columns are displayed



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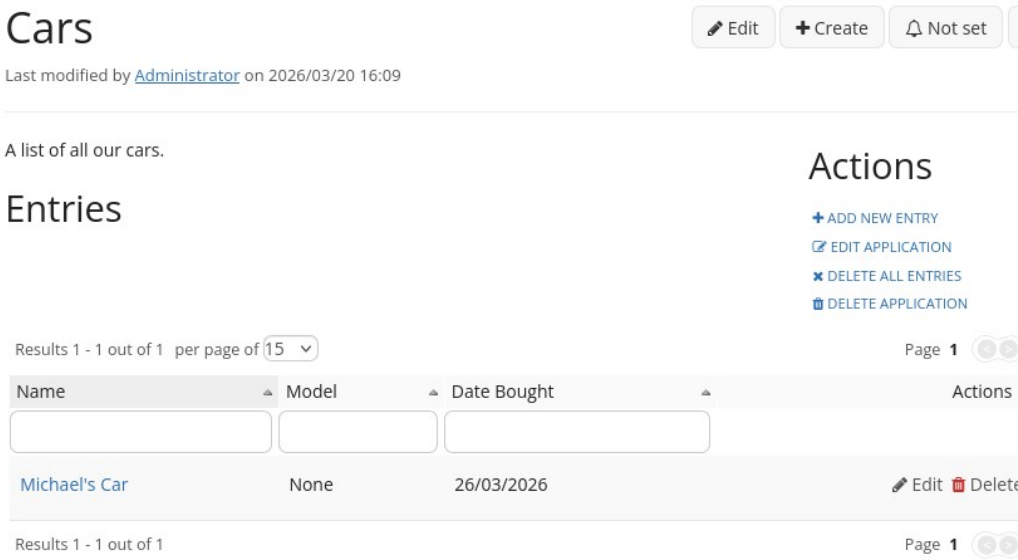
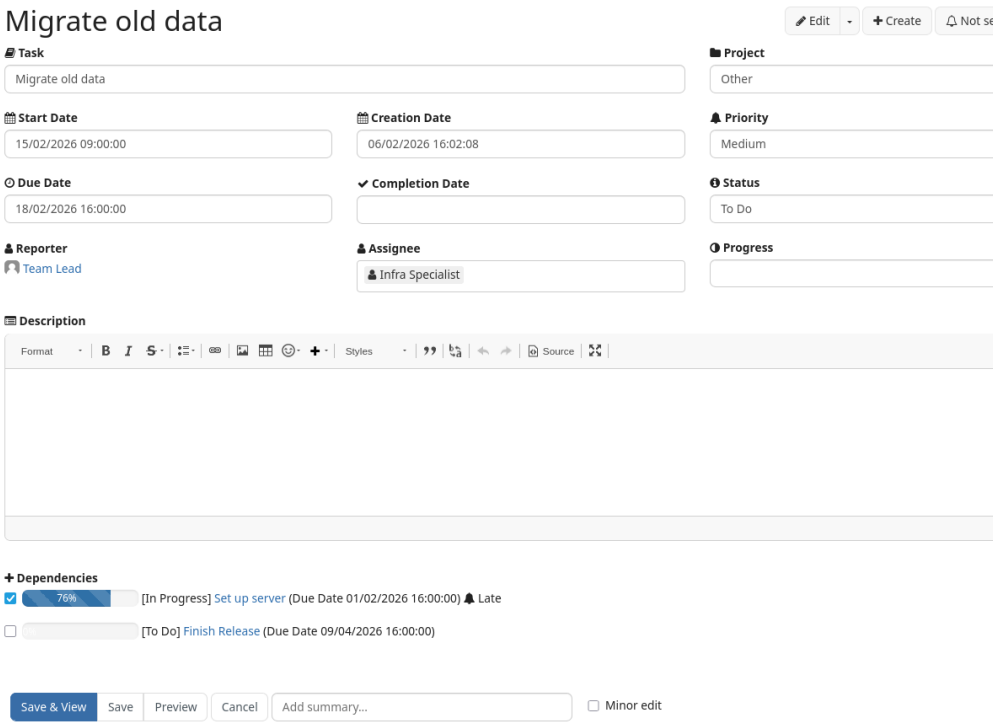
App Within Minutes

- Main page lists entries
- Supports filters and sorting



App Within Minutes

- Generated code can be customized, frequently basis for more complex applications.
  Example: Task manager
- Custom design, logic, etc.



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Funding XWiki

About XWiki SAS

- Founded in 2004 by Ludovic Dubost
- Independent company in France and Romania
- 75 employees
- Provides services, training, support and hosting (cloud) around XWiki
- Sponsors most of the development of XWiki and CryptPad (end-to-end encrypted collaborative editing of documents)
- > 5 million EUR annual revenue since 2024 including research projects

XWiki SAS and XWiki.org

- Separation between the company and the open-source project, no CLA
- All decisions in the open-source project are taken by committers
- Committers inspired by ASF
  - Committers vote who becomes committer
- Companies that employ at least one committer advertise their services
- Top sponsoring company has more options
- Currently XWiki SAS is the only sponsoring company

Separation challenges

- Some customers post in the community forum
- Differentiation between community and company needs training
- Participating in the community without replacing professional support
- For every change: internal and external discussion
- CTO Vincent Massol helps by reminding us about the separation and participating in the community

Community challenges

- Codebase grew in the 20+ years of constant development
- Can be hard for external contributors to contribute
- Even just following everything is hard
- **Main community contributions**: Translations, extensions, forum, bugs

Main countermeasure:

Keep APIs stable so customizations and extensions keep working

Funding open source

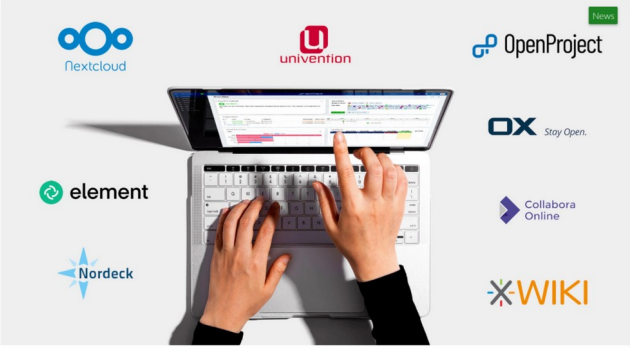
- Services, customizations and research projects rarely fund maintenance work
- Recurring revenue from support is **key**

But why should users pay?

One answer: Paid extensions

- Open source, but include check for licence key
- Paid licences includes support / support contracts include licences

Digital sovereignty



The rise of the Sovereign Workplace: OpenDesk – Your open source alternative to Microsoft and Google

- Recent focus on sovereign and open-source solutions
- Open source provides true control: full transparency, other vendors could take over
- XWiki is part of **openDesk**
- Collaboration between XWiki and software vendors like **OpenProject**, **Nextcloud**, and **Collabora Online**, developing integrations
- XWiki has a task manager and OpenProject has a wiki, but neither can’t replace each other/ integration makes sense

Atlassian

- Confluence and Jira are widely used
- Price increases in 2024: server products discontinued
- 2029: EOL Atlassian datacenter product, for some ~3 years extended maintenance – creates surge of interest
- **XWiki** had basic migration solution for years
- Migration projects funded improvements for the Confluence Migrator
- 2024/2025: scaling with larger migrations
- **Ongoing**: Migrating XWiki + OpenProject together as an open-source alternative stack to Atlassian

Migration challenges

- Surge of interest:
  - Hard to scale up quickly without investors
  - Unclear future, as demand might go down
- Users don’t have plain Confluence – many plugins, custom macros, etc.

XWiki approach:

- Automate migrations, so simple ones can be performed without our intervention
- Re-implemented many macros, plugins on top of XWiki
- Build a network of partners

DokuWiki vs. XWiki

Why I joined XWiki SAS

- My **dream**: be paid to work on open source
- Before joining XWiki SAS, **DokuWiki** was main project I was involved
- So: let's make money with DokuWiki?
- The truth:
  nobody works fulltime on DokuWiki core, more than 5 on XWiki
- Let's explore why

Similarities

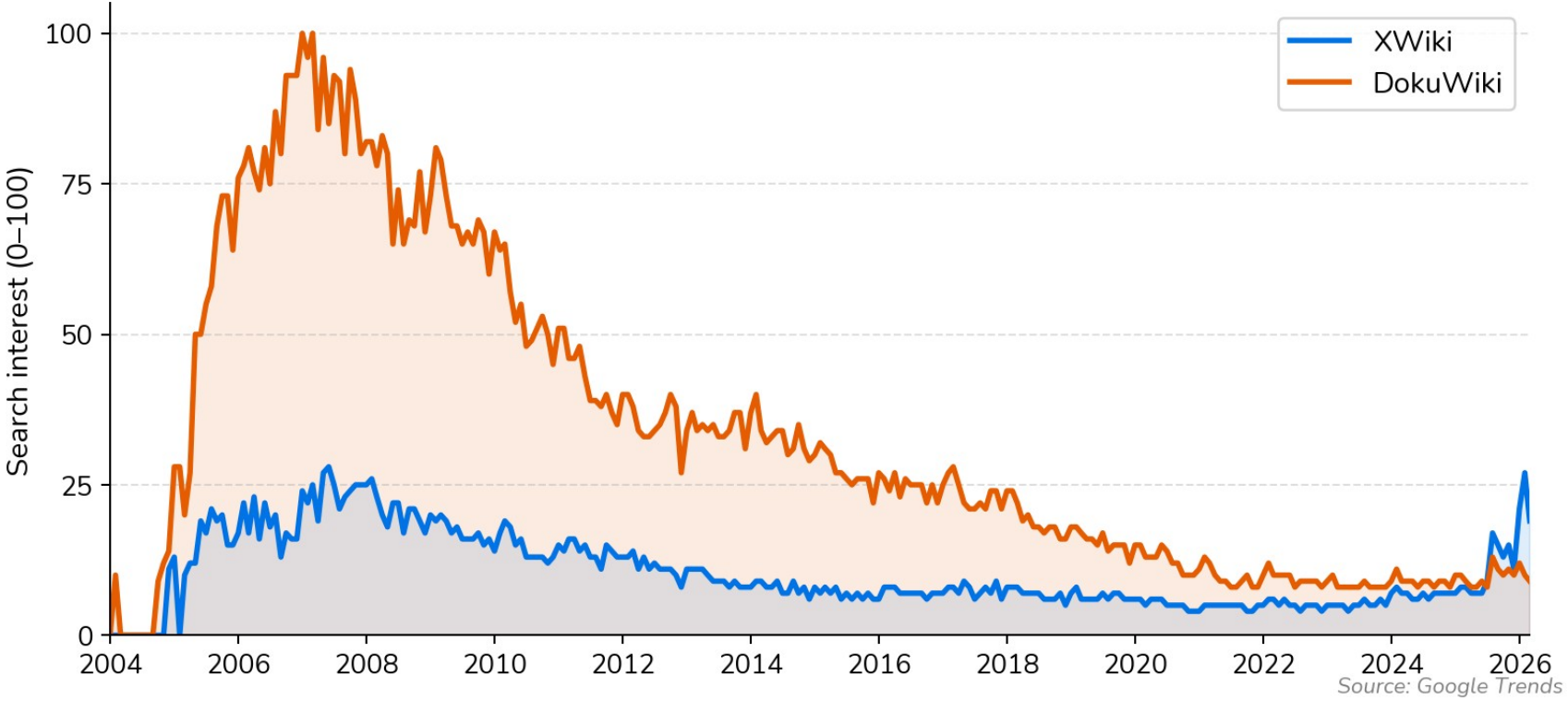
- **Age**: initial release 2004 (XWiki in January, DokuWiki in July)
- **Core features**: pages, links, history, media files, access control
- **Use cases** (intranet, public website, personal wiki, ...)
- Many **extensions** (> 1400 DokuWiki, ~ 960 XWiki)
- **Advanced features**: Structured data, PDF export, office export, WYSIWYG editor in DokuWiki as plugin, XWiki as core feature

Popularity?

Questions:

1) Who knew about **XWiki** before this event?
2) Who knew about **DokuWiki** before this event?

XWiki vs DokuWiki – Google Search Interest Over Time



Some hypotheses

- DokuWiki is too “simple”, many people know a little PHP, DIY instead of paying
- DokuWiki doesn’t “check all boxes”?
- XWiki has better marketing, connections?
- Luck?
- Something else?

Summary

- Separation between the company and the open-source project creates room for community but needs work to keep it alive
- Paid extensions bring value to support contracts
- Checking boxes might be important to win customers
- Collaboration with other projects is key
- Digital sovereignty and Confluence migrations create surge of interest

Questions? Feedback?

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More at xwiki.org